



IIT ROORKEE



NPTEL ONLINE
CERTIFICATION COURSE

Public Speaking

Lecture 27: Meta-communication

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“When we no longer use communication to communicate but to **communicate about communication**, as we inevitably must in communication research, then we use conceptualizations that are not part of, but about communication. This is called **meta-communication.**” (288)

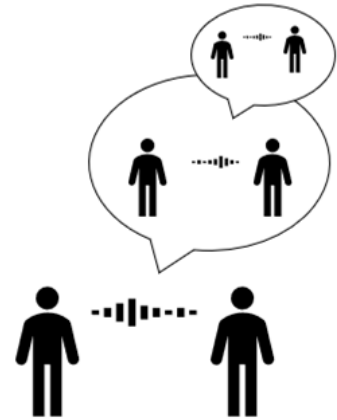
- Paul Watzlawick in his book *Pragmatics of Human Communication*



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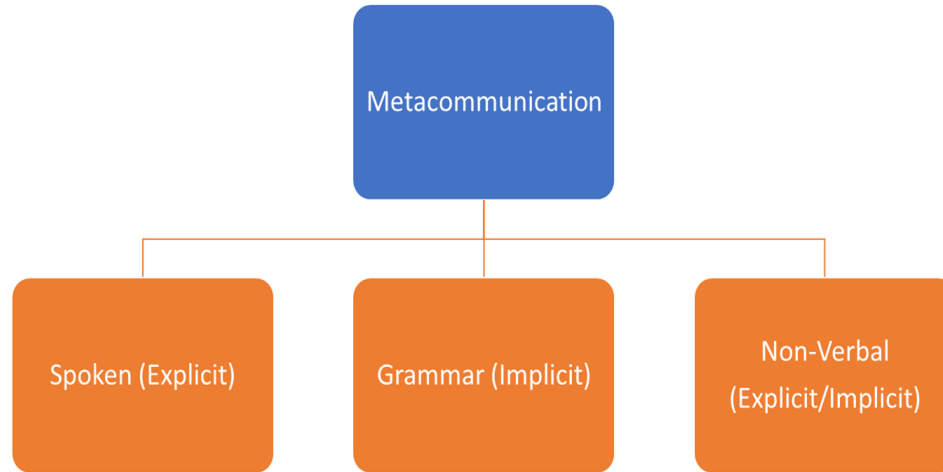
Introduction

- Gregory Bateson and Jurgen Ruesch introduced the term meta-communication in 1951.
- It was through their publication of the book *Communication: The Social Matrix of Psychiatry*.
- The term means “communication about communication”.
- Meta-communication refers to one’s ability to convey multiple messages simultaneously.
- It is a secondary form of communication on meaning-making and interpretation.



Communication *about* Communication

Components of Meta-communication



- Negotiation happens between these three realms.
- Each realm may **support/contradict** the communication established by another.

Examples of Meta-communication

Stephen Tyler in his book *Said and the Unsaid* illustrates a few examples of meta-communication being direct and indirect in nature :

Direct (What is being said)	Indirect (How it is said)
I'm only joking	Tone of voice
This is serious	Intonation
When I say X, I mean Y	Gestures
This is only hearsay, but...	Posture
I heard that...	Eye movements
I'm speaking to you as a friend	Facial Expression

Meta-language

- Logician Alfred Tarski introduced the term “meta-language” in the year 1933.
- Like meta-communication, it implies the employment of language to understand better about language.
- In meta-language, language evolves from being a means of communication (process) to the reason (cause) of communication in itself.
- Meta-language essentially comprises **grammar** as its fundamental aspect.
- Grammatical knowledge enables participants to have a proper grip on meta-linguistic abilities.

Meta-communication in Indian Background

- Tarski's concept of metalanguage was introduced to the field of Indian logic and grammar in the year 1962.
- Scholars like Staal and Scharfe juxtaposed meta-language with Panini's grammar for critical study.
- Frits Staal argues that the ideas on meta-communication were prevalent in ancient Indian discourses themselves.
 - *Upadeśa* (the language of grammatical instruction)
 - *Anubandha* (metalinguistic marker)

Communication and Meta-communication

- Communication theorists deconstructed the communication as an action into two essential components:
 - a. Content
 - b. Relationship
- The content denotes the meaning that the verbal and non-verbal codes signify.
- While the relationship denotes the sequential and contextual value.

“Every communication has a content and a relationship aspect such that the latter classifies the former and is, therefore, a meta-communication” (Watzlawick 54).

Silence as Meta-communication

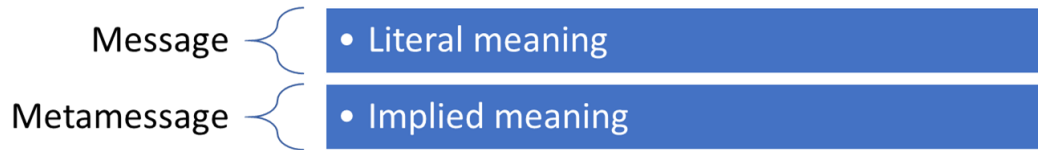
- “Activity or inactivity, words or silence all have message value: they influence” (Watzlawick 49).
- Adding on to the three realms of meta-communication, silence occupies an integral part of conveying meaning.
- Even the physical stillness of the speaker, at times, gets attributed to **postural silence**.
- Some communication theorists find the meaning generated by silence direct, while others appreciate the meaning of silence in its ambiguity (Penna 10).

Advantages of Pauses

- ✓ In public speaking, pauses are employed to emphasize and add weight to the content delivered.
- ✓ It can benefit both the reader and listener by providing a sufficient time gap before shifting from one topic to another.
- ✓ Pauses provide time-space for the speaker to avail more precision in their choice of words.
- ✓ It is an integral part of active listening where the speaker cares to listen to the questions/suggestions from the other end.

Meta-message

- ❖ An underlying meaning.
- ❖ A meta-message is what is communicated but not said.
- ❖ It could be understood when **read between the lines**.
- ❖ It conveys the speaker's attitude and feelings.



Factors Controlling Meta-message

Environment

Behaviour

Skills

Needs

Appeal

Beliefs

Derrida's Graphematic Structure of Communication

- French philosopher Jacques Derrida critiques the viewpoint of perceiving communication as solely phonocentric.
- He argues that any form of communication essentially incorporates a structure of writing for itself.
- The term “graphematics” refers to the linguistic field of studying writing systems and their basic components, i.e. graphemes.
- Writing as a communicative system always supplements the verbal part.
- “Meta-communication pastes itself on communication, it is not possible to turn communication discrete” (Mateus 7).

Meta-communication in Digital Medium

- ❑ Communication through texting platforms such as Facebook, Twitter, Instagram etc., deals a lot with metacommunication. For instance, in texting,
 - All capitals would mean an excited state of response.
 - Lack of emojis may express disinterestedness.
 - Skipping salutations and greeting in e-mail writing becomes rude and informal.
 - Leaving people's text "on read" signifies **virtual silence** as a part of meta-communication.



How to Meta-communicate Properly?

- ❖ Awareness of one's meta-communicative approach makes the overall transmission of the intended message fluent and smooth.
- ❖ The proper combination of intended words and unintended cues determines the effectiveness of the message.
- ❖ Interests, feelings and emotions could be transferred well through effective meta-communication.
- ❖ Language and Paralanguage go hand in hand for establishing better communication.

“One cannot not communicate.”
- Paul Watzlawick

Thank You

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